

A Sign Between Him and His People

Why the Sabbath Matters to YHWH, and Why He Made It for You

A Midrash Study on the Seventh Day Sabbath

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah restored. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Out of every way the Creator could have marked the people who belong to him, he chose a day. Not a building, not a uniform, not a ritual object. A day of rest, set apart and made holy before there was ever a nation of Israel.

YHWH calls the Sabbath **a sign between him and his people**. And Yahshua says it was **made for man**. Both are true at the same time. It is his mark on us, and it is his gift to us. It blesses the body, it restores the soul, and it tells the world whose we are.

SECTION I

Before Sinai: The Sabbath Was Built Into Creation

The Sabbath does not begin with Moses. It begins in the first week of the world. In Genesis 2:1-3, when the heavens and the earth were finished, Elohim rested on the seventh day, blessed it, and made it holy. That is the first time Scripture uses the word holy, *qadash*, and the first thing it is spoken over is not a place or a person. It is a day.

The Hebrew verb *shabat* means to cease, to stop. YHWH did not rest because he was tired. He stopped because the work was complete, and then he set the stopping apart as holy. The seventh day is woven into the design of time itself, the same way marriage is woven into the design of the first family in the very next verses.

Israel was keeping the Sabbath before the Ten Commandments were ever spoken. In Exodus 16, the manna fell six days and not the seventh, and YHWH gave a double portion on the sixth day so his people could rest. Moses told them plainly that YHWH had given them the Sabbath (**Exodus 16:29**). It was a gift before it was written on stone.

Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. You shall labor six days, and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to YHWH your Elohim. You shall not do any work in it, you, nor your son, nor your daughter, your male servant, nor your female servant, nor your livestock, nor your stranger who is within your gates; for in six days YHWH made heaven and earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested the seventh day; therefore YHWH blessed the Sabbath day, and made it holy.

EXODUS 20:8-11

Notice the word **remember**. You do not tell someone to remember something brand new. The fourth commandment points back to creation. And it is the longest of the ten, the one YHWH took the most words to explain.

SECTION II

The Sign: His Mark on His People

Most certainly you shall keep my Sabbaths; for it is a sign between me and you throughout your generations, that you may know that I am YHWH who sanctifies you.

EXODUS 31:13

Therefore the children of Israel shall keep the Sabbath, to observe the Sabbath throughout their generations, for a perpetual covenant. It is a sign between me and the children of Israel forever; for in six days YHWH made heaven and earth, and on the seventh day he rested, and was refreshed.

EXODUS 31:16-17

The Hebrew word for sign is *oth*. It is a mark, a token, a visible witness that points to something real. Scripture uses that same word for the other great covenant markers YHWH gave:

Genesis 9:12-13	The rainbow, the sign of the covenant YHWH made with Noah and every living creature.
Genesis 17:11	Circumcision, the sign of the covenant with Abraham and his seed.
Exodus 12:13	The blood on the doorposts, a sign that the destroyer would pass over the house.
Exodus 31:13, 17	The Sabbath, the sign between YHWH and his people throughout their generations.
Ezekiel 20:12, 20	The Sabbaths again, given so his people would know that he is YHWH who sanctifies them.

Read carefully what the sign says. It is not a sign that we are good enough. It is a sign **that you may know that I am YHWH who sanctifies you**. To sanctify is to set apart. The Sabbath is not how we make ourselves holy. It is the weekly witness that **he** is the one who sets us apart. Every seventh day, when we stop, we are confessing with our whole week that he is our Elohim and we are his.

Moreover also I gave them my Sabbaths, to be a sign between me and them, that they might know that I am YHWH who sanctifies them.

EZEKIEL 20:12

Ezekiel 20 is also a warning. Over and over in that chapter YHWH names the same two charges against his people: they walked away from his instructions, and they profaned his Sabbaths (**Ezekiel 20:13, 16, 21, 24**). In that chapter the two go together with the idols they turned to. When a people stops keeping the sign, it is usually because their heart has already started belonging to something else.

SAY IT PLAINLY

A sign is something other people can see. Anyone can say they belong to YHWH. The Sabbath is where it shows up on the calendar. **What you stop for tells the world who you belong to.**

SECTION III

Who Are His People? The Door Was Always Open

Some will say the Sabbath was only for Israel. Look at who YHWH included from the very beginning. The fourth commandment itself names **the stranger within your gates (Exodus 20:10)**. When Israel came out of Egypt, a mixed multitude came with them (**Exodus 12:38**), and YHWH gave one instruction for the native born and for the stranger who joined himself to Israel (**Exodus 12:49; Numbers 15:15-16**).

Then Isaiah speaks to the outsiders directly. In Isaiah 56:1-8, the foreigner who joins himself to YHWH, loves his name, keeps the Sabbath from profaning it, and holds fast his covenant is promised a place on his holy mountain and joy in his house of prayer, which is to be called a house of prayer for all peoples. The Sabbath is named right there as a mark of the foreigner who has come in.

Paul says the same thing from the other side of the stake. Gentiles who come to Messiah are grafted into the olive tree (**Romans 11:17-24**). Those who were once strangers to the covenants of promise are now fellow citizens with the holy ones and members of the household of Elohim (**Ephesians 2:12-19**). If you belong to Messiah, you are Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise (**Galatians 3:29**).

GRAFTED IN MEANS WELCOMED IN

Being grafted in does not make you a second class branch with a different set of instructions. It makes you part of the same tree, drawing from the same root. **The sign he gave his people is offered to everyone who comes into his people.**

SECTION IV

Made for Man: Rest for the Body

He said to them, "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. Therefore the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath."

MARK 2:27-28

Yahshua said this while the religious leaders were accusing his disciples over a handful of grain. He was not tearing down the Sabbath. He was tearing down the idea that it was a cage. The word he used for man, *anthropos*, means mankind. The Sabbath was made for human beings, for their good, from the week of creation on.

The Word for Refreshed

In Exodus 23:12 YHWH commands rest on the seventh day so that the ox and the donkey may rest, and the son of the servant and the stranger may be refreshed. That Hebrew word is *naphash*. It comes from the same root as *nephesh*, the word for soul, life, and breath. It means to catch your breath, to be refreshed in your very being.

Now look back at Exodus 31:17. After six days of creating, YHWH rested **and was refreshed**. It is the same word. The One who never grows weary (**Isaiah 40:28**) uses the language of catching his breath, and then he invites the servant, the stranger, and even the animals into that same breath. The Sabbath is YHWH sharing his own rest with his creation.

Rest Is Freedom

You shall remember that you were a servant in the land of Egypt, and YHWH your Elohim brought you out of there by a mighty hand and by an outstretched arm. Therefore YHWH your Elohim commanded you to keep the Sabbath day.

DEUTERONOMY 5:15

When Moses repeats the commandment in Deuteronomy 5, he gives a second reason. Exodus 20 points back to creation. Deuteronomy 5 points back to deliverance. Slaves do not get a day off. In Egypt the people made bricks every day with no end, and when Moses asked for time to worship, Pharaoh complained that they were making the people rest from their burdens (**Exodus 5:5**). The Hebrew verb Pharaoh used there comes from *shabat*. Pharaoh saw rest as a threat. YHWH made it a commandment.

THE PICTURE

Every Sabbath is a weekly Exodus. **A slave cannot stop. A son can.** When you lay your work down on the seventh day, you are declaring that Pharaoh no longer owns your time, your body, or your household.

YHWH knew what we would do to ourselves without it. He built rest into the week for the worker, for the family, for the servant, for the animals, and he even gave the land its own Sabbath year (**Leviticus 25:1-7**). His design is that nothing he made should be worked without end. The same Elohim who formed the body knows exactly what the body needs.

SECTION V

Rest for the Soul: The Spiritual Side of the Sabbath

If you turn away your foot from the Sabbath, from doing your pleasure on my holy day, and call the Sabbath a delight, and the holy of YHWH honorable, and shall honor it, not doing your own ways, nor finding your own pleasure, nor speaking your own words, then you will delight yourself in YHWH, and I will make you to ride on the high places of the earth, and I will feed you with the heritage of Jacob your father; for YHWH's mouth has spoken it.

ISAIAH 58:13-14

Isaiah does not call the Sabbath a burden. He calls it **a delight**, and he promises that the one who treats it that way will delight in YHWH himself. Clearing the day of our own work and our own agenda is what makes room for him. You cannot hear a still small voice in a week that never goes quiet.

The Sabbath is also the first appointed time YHWH lists. In Leviticus 23, before Passover, before Shavuot, before Tabernacles, he names the weekly Sabbath as a holy convocation (**Leviticus 23:1-3**). The Hebrew *miqra qodesh* comes from *qara*, to call, to summon. Every seventh day is a holy summons. He is calling his people to meet with him. Scripture even gives a song written for the day, Psalm 92, A Song for the Sabbath Day, and it opens with thanksgiving and praise.

Yahshua, the Rest Giver

Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart; and you will find rest for your souls.

MATTHEW 11:28-29

Right after he says this, Matthew 12 opens on the Sabbath. That is not an accident. The One who offers rest for the soul is the same One who is Lord of the Sabbath. He does not replace the day. He fills it.

There remains therefore a Sabbath rest for the people of Elohim. For he who has entered into his rest has himself also rested from his works, as Elohim did from his.

HEBREWS 4:9-10

In Hebrews 4:9 the writer uses a word found nowhere else in the New Testament: *sabbatismos*, a Sabbath keeping. Hebrews 4 does point forward to the final rest of the Kingdom, but the word it chose to describe what remains for the people of Elohim is literally the keeping of a Sabbath. The weekly Sabbath is a foretaste of the rest that is still coming.

SECTION VI

How Yahshua Kept the Sabbath

He came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up. He entered, as was his custom, into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and stood up to read.

LUKE 4:16

Yahshua never broke the Sabbath. He broke the traditions men had piled on top of it. He taught that the commandments of YHWH must never be set aside for the traditions of men (**Mark 7:6-9**). Every Sabbath argument in the Gospels is about man made rules, not about whether the day still stands.

Of how much more value then is a man than a sheep! Therefore it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath day.

MATTHEW 12:12

Look at what he chose to do on the Sabbath:

- He healed a man with a withered hand in front of the ones watching to accuse him. **Matthew 12:9-13**
- He set free a woman who had been bent over for eighteen years. **Luke 13:10-17**
- He healed a man who had been sick for thirty eight years at the pool of Bethesda. **John 5:1-9**
- He opened the eyes of a man born blind. **John 9:1-14**

Ought not this woman, being a daughter of Abraham, whom Satan had bound eighteen long years, be freed from this bondage on the Sabbath day?

LUKE 13:16

DELIVERANCE ON THE SABBATH

Yahshua did not treat the Sabbath as a day when deliverance had to wait. He treated it as the most fitting day for it. **The day that remembers the Exodus is the day he loosed a daughter of Abraham from Satan's bondage.**

Even after his death, his closest followers kept the day. The women prepared spices and ointments, and on the Sabbath they rested according to the commandment (**Luke 23:56**). Years later Paul, as his custom was, reasoned in the synagogues on the Sabbath (**Acts 17:2; 18:4**), and in Pisidian Antioch the Gentiles asked to hear the word the next Sabbath, and almost the whole city gathered (**Acts 13:42-44**).

SECTION VII

What Scripture Actually Asks

Over the centuries men have built walls of rules around the Sabbath until the gift became a weight. Strip those away and look at what YHWH actually wrote. His instructions for the day are simple:

Rest	Stop from your ordinary labor. The seventh day is a Sabbath to YHWH. Exodus 20:9-10
Do no work	You shall not do any work in it. Exodus 20:10; Deuteronomy 5:14
Do not cause others to work	Not your children, your servants, your animals, or the stranger with you. Exodus 20:10; Deuteronomy 5:14
Do not buy or sell	Nehemiah shut the gates of Jerusalem to keep merchants out, and the people vowed not to buy on the Sabbath. Nehemiah 10:31; 13:15-22
Keep it holy	Set it apart from the other six. Call it a delight and honor it. Exodus 20:8; Isaiah 58:13
Do good	Heal, help, rescue, show mercy. Yahshua said it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath. Matthew 12:12

When It Begins

Scripture counts a day from evening. Creation says there was evening and there was morning (**Genesis 1:5**), and appointed days are kept from evening to evening (**Leviticus 23:32**). Nehemiah closed the gates as it began to grow dark before the Sabbath (**Nehemiah 13:19**). And in Mark 1:32, the crowds waited until the sun had set before they brought their sick to Yahshua. The Sabbath runs from sunset on the sixth day to sunset on the seventh.

WHAT IT CAN LOOK LIKE IN A HOME

Stay home. Sleep in. Open the Word together as a family. Worship with music. Eat well and enjoy the table. Put down the work, the shopping, and the worry. Let the day breathe.

None of that is a new rule. It is simply what happens when a household takes YHWH at his word and **stops**.

SECTION VIII

Was It Ever Changed?

There is no verse anywhere in Scripture where YHWH, Yahshua, or any apostle moves the Sabbath to another day or ends it. Yahshua said he did not come to destroy the instructions or the prophets but to fulfill them, and that not the smallest letter would pass away while heaven and earth remain (**Matthew 5:17-18**). Isaiah even looks ahead to

the new heavens and the new earth:

"It shall happen that from one new moon to another, and from one Sabbath to another, all flesh will come to worship before me," says YHWH.

ISAIAH 66:23

The shift to the first day came later, through church and empire, not through Scripture. In AD 321 the Roman emperor Constantine decreed rest on the venerable day of the sun. Decades later the church council held at Laodicea told believers not to rest on the Sabbath like the Jews, but to work on it and honor the first day instead (Canon 29). The church and Rome did what Scripture never did.

The New Testament does record believers gathering on the first day (**Acts 20:7; 1 Corinthians 16:2**). Gathering on a day is not the same as transferring the Sabbath rest to it. Believers met daily in the temple and from house to house (**Acts 2:46**), and no one argues that made every day the Sabbath.

Honest Answers to Common Objections

Let no one therefore judge you in eating, or in drinking, or with respect to a feast day or a new moon or a Sabbath day, which are a shadow of the things to come; but the body is Messiah's.

COLOSSIANS 2:16-17

- **Colossians 2:16-17.** Paul tells the believers not to let anyone judge them regarding Sabbaths. The ones judging in Colossae were pushing man made regulations and harsh treatment of the body (**Colossians 2:20-23**). Paul also calls these days a shadow of things **to come**. A shadow of something still coming is not a shadow that has passed away.
- **Romans 14:5-6.** The chapter is about disputable matters, eating and fasting and esteeming days. The Sabbath is never named in the chapter, and Paul would not call one of the Ten Commandments a matter of opinion.
- **Galatians 4:8-10.** Paul is speaking to former pagans about turning back to the weak and beggarly elements they served when they did not know Elohim. That was their pagan past, not the Sabbath of YHWH.
- **Hebrews 4.** As shown above, the chapter uses the word *sabbatismos* to say a Sabbath keeping remains for the people of Elohim.

THE TEST WE APPLY

Where Scripture speaks, we follow it. Where Scripture is silent, we do not make up a commandment, and we do not make up a cancellation either. **No verse ends the Sabbath, and no verse moves it.**

SECTION IX

Enter the Sabbath Forgiven and Forgiving

This is where the Sabbath meets the heart of everything we teach at Kingdom Life. You can stop working on the seventh day and still carry a war inside you. You can keep the day on the calendar and still be bound on the inside.

Isaiah 58 is the same chapter that calls the Sabbath a delight, and it begins with YHWH describing the fast he has chosen: to loosen the bonds of wickedness, to undo the straps of the yoke, and to let the oppressed go free (**Isaiah**

58:6). Loosing chains and Sabbath delight sit in the same chapter. Deliverance and rest belong together.

Be angry, and don't sin. Don't let the sun go down on your wrath, and don't give place to the devil.

EPHESIANS 4:26-27

The Sabbath begins when the sun goes down. What better moment to obey this verse. Before the sun sets on the sixth day, settle it. Forgive the one who wronged you. Ask forgiveness from the one you wronged, especially inside your own home. Pride will tell you to hold it. Humility lets it go, and forgiveness opens the door to deliverance.

THE ORDER OF THINGS

Humility is the root of forgiveness. Forgiveness is the root of deliverance. And a delivered heart is a heart that can finally rest.

Do not bring unforgiveness into his holy day. Lay it down with your work.

SECTION X

Walking It Out This Week

Practical, simple, and small enough to actually start this coming Sabbath.

- 1 Prepare on the sixth day.** Like the double portion of manna, get food, errands, and shopping done before sunset so the day is truly free.
- 2 Make peace before sunset.** Forgive one specific thing, and ask forgiveness for one specific thing, before the sun goes down.
- 3 Mark the beginning.** Gather your household as the sun sets. Pray, bless one another, and welcome the day on purpose.
- 4 Put the work away.** Close the laptop, silence the work phone, and let the ordinary week stop.
- 5 Open the Word together.** Read one passage from this study as a family and talk about it.
- 6 Worship and delight.** Sing, eat well, sleep, walk outside. Call the Sabbath a delight and treat it like one.
- 7 Do good.** Visit someone, check on someone, help someone. Yahshua used the day to heal and set free.

